

Instant Messengers Compared					
	MSN	Yahoo!	AIM	ICQ	IndiaTimes
Emoticons	Could do better	Good looks and variety	Not the very best	None here	Try these at your own risk!
Video and voice conferencing	Netmeeting is good for video chat, bad for voice chat	With a fast connection this is the best for voice and video chat	No video chat here	Make do with only text	A simple desi text messenger
SMS Facility	—	—	—	Send an SMS via leading mobile service providers	—
Buddy search	You need the e-mail address or sign-in name	Search is easy and includes parameters such as interest, age, and sex	Often results in search errors	Search on various parameters and add buddies with a single click	Missing in action!
Message archiving	Save messages manually	Optional feature	No archiving option	Enabled by default	Out of the question
Maximum characters allowed	400	800	1,024	Online: 7,000 Offline: 450	150

data is seamlessly relayed to the audio server, which buffers and sends it to the receiver. Owing to the speed at which this happens, you do not experience a lag in the voice (provided you have a high speed Internet connection). You would find an apparent lag while using a dial-up Internet connection. So you can now save a bundle on a long distance call to that interesting girl you met on the Net the other day!

Video communication is an altogether different ball game. The client receives the frame from your Web cam and sends it to the viewers connected to your Web cam without passing through an intermediate media server. A noticeable delay in frame rate and refresh rate makes it quite like a slow motion video, but that's inevitable because of the congestion that would exist on the network. Video quality can improve and match real life speeds if the connection was dedicated solely to video relay. The video quality might also depend on the quality of the camera in use.

Is reliability at stake?

Most messengers use the ASCII text mode, which means all your messages are sent as plain text between the server and the client. Since messages are sent mostly as unencrypted data and they travel through public networks, the risk of being snooped on is pretty high. Messenger service providers warn you of potential hazards in sharing personal information on the Web. It's possible for a professional to sniff the data packets and steal your personal informa-

tion when it is sent across. Sniffing agents and packet snatching programs are available on the Net in plenty. A hacker might use any of these programs to catch data packets that travel over public networks. Since the messages are in plain text, the hacker has less to do on deciphering them.

Messengers are not meant for exchange of secure information. Flaws in the messaging client can be exploited by hackers to plant malicious code on your computer. Besides, a class of messenger viruses have started causing havoc. George Bush and Pic 1324 are two such viruses. They come to you as a file sent from one of your friend's virus infested computer. When you accept the file on the messenger, your PC gets infected and a file called msgsprd.exe is copied into the memory. Once the program is actively resident in the memory, it starts spreading to other contacts on your buddy list.

The last word

Instant messaging has created a new paradigm on the Internet. It's the most preferred application of the Net after e-mail. Not just individuals but also businesses have started looking at instant messaging as a cheaper alternative to communicate with their customers and clients. Businesses can have closed instant messaging solutions deployed on their networks to increase security and privacy, while also cutting down on communication costs. Exchange 2000, the messaging software that's available from Microsoft allows you to deploy instant messaging solutions at the corporate level.

Desperately Seeking You

Yair Goldfinger, Arik Vardi, Sefi Vigiser, and Amnon Amir. They are the brains behind ICQ (I Seek You), the world's most popular instant messenger from Mirabilis, a company formed by the foursome. Back in 1996 when the Internet was gathering momentum among the masses, Mirabilis realised that something was lacking in the whole concept of the Internet—interaction. The missing link was instant messaging. ICQ enticed its users with new features such as user created public and private chat rooms. Soon the online community sprang into a large ensemble of special interest groups. Today ICQ has improved many-fold and offers its customers a highly integrated messenger that includes an e-mail facility, option to send and receive SMS, make phone calls from PC to PC for free or to a phone from your PC at very minimal charges. Palm, Pocket PC and Windows CE versions of ICQ for the PDA are also available.

Today IMs are mostly used at a personal level. The potential to extend an IM's interoperability can enhance communication and take it to new heights. Open source clients such as Jabber give you the flexibility of using messengers on varied platforms such as PDAs and other mobile devices. SMS has already integrated itself with messaging. Instant messaging will evolve to a service where you can talk to devices from any platform and every device available on earth.

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